of the West's dialogue with the Taliban and also sympathised with it to an extent. However, they remained 'very cautious about being part of the reconciliation process, and simply refused to engage.'[101] Rakesh Sood confirms that India was in disagreement with H and other Western officials working on the reconciliation agenda and deliberately kept away from it. Though heavily clued into the discussions, Rakesh Sood decided not to jump on the Western bandwagon but instead support the Afghan government to set its own terms for talks. 'The British and other Western officials were trying to get ahead of the Afghans themselves in terms of saying … irrespective of any terms and conditions we should have dialogue', but this what not how India was guiding its Afghanistan policy.[102] He told his British (and some US) counterparts that India was 'quite sure that any lasting reconciliation will be one that is led by the Afghans, negotiated by the Afghans, and takes into account their [Afghan] concerns, rather than deadlines of exit and withdrawal which are dictated by domestic public opinion in Western capitals'.[103] Taking into account Karzai's attitude towards reconciliation and that of other Afghan politicians such as Abdullah, India decided not to get involved with London on Afghanistan. Instead, it would try and undercut any format of reconciliation that would undermine the Afghan government or treat the two sides which were, Kabul and the Taliban, at par.

Competing models of reconciliation

The London conference significantly impacted India's approach towards Afghanistan. On one hand New Delhi criticised the UK and the US for giving Pakistan a major role in the reconciliation. But on the other hand, it nuanced its stance on reconciliation by highlighting the 'red lines' for such talks to move ahead and introducing preconditions that would allow the talks to be Afghan-led and Afghan-owned. Kabul supported India's stance. Concerned that London's attempt at a time-bound withdrawal would allow Pakistan to determine the terms of reconciliation, senior Afghan politicians began pushing India take a hard line on the issue as they were not in a position to do the same.[104] Forced to play his hand in London, Karzai too became disillusioned by London's initiatives. To steer the initiative away from the UK (and Islamabad), Karzai organised the